



RECYCLING

One of the key functions of an ecosystem is to recycle energy, water, and nutrients. Recycling is a vital process. If any of the substances needed for life became locked up in a form where they couldn't be used, life would eventually grind to a halt. Some of these cycles can take millions of years to complete, others as little as a day.

The carbon cycle

The carbon cycle is a good example of how essential elements are recycled. Plants take carbon dioxide out of the atmosphere to use in photosynthesis (see pp.18–19). Animals eat the plants and build the carbon into their muscles. They also breathe carbon dioxide back into the air. Dead animals and plants are broken down by decomposers, which release the carbon back into the soil.

